

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Growing tension over CPS budget

Borrowing, pensions and TIFs: What's fueling the standoff?

By **Nell Salzman**
and **Kate Perez**
Chicago Tribune

Chicago Board of Education President Sean Harden has challenged the district's new proposed budget, expressing doubts about its heavy reliance on revenue from special taxing districts to close a \$734 million deficit.

The hesitancy repeatedly expressed by Harden, who was appointed by Mayor Brandon

Johnson, during two public hearings Tuesday signals further growing tension within the school board over how to address the district's deepening fiscal crisis.

Chicago Public Schools' fiscal road map, backed by interim CEO Macquiline King, runs counter to the agenda of Johnson, a former Chicago Teachers Union organizer, who has advocated both now and in the past for borrowing to address budget woes. The standoff illustrates two entrenched sides —

the mayor, Harden and their allies who support borrowing, against board members and advocates who don't — digging in just over a week before the district is required by law to balance its budget.

In the auditorium at CPS headquarters in the Loop Tuesday, the board's divide over the budget — between elected and mayoral-appointed board members — was on full display. After parents, educa-

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Chicago Teachers Union Vice President Jackson Potter speaks with members of the press outside Chicago Public Schools headquarters during the district's budget hearings on Tuesday. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/TRIBUNE**



Angel Santiago, who is legally blind, holds his dachshund, Bam Bam, as they arrive at Niles Animal Hospital with the help of friend Nico Zayas on Wednesday. The stolen service dog was reunited with Santiago on Tuesday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

'Bam Bam is my world'

The support dog stolen in June is reunited with his Logan Square owner

By **William Tong**
Chicago Tribune

Bam Bam is home.

The 14-year-old dachshund captured hearts and minds around the globe after he'd been reported stolen in June from Angel Santiago, his Logan Square owner. Santiago is legally blind because of glaucoma and relied on Bam Bam as an emotional support dog.

The pair were reunited Tuesday night, police said, after a man and woman dropped Bam Bam

off at the Chicago police 16th District station. Officers said the dog appeared in good health. Detectives are still investigating the theft, and no one is in custody.

Santiago told the Tribune Wednesday morning he thanked God for being reunited with his beloved Bam Bam.

"I prayed every day and night," he said.

Bam Bam was stolen from Santiago's yard the night of June 5, according to police. The news of the theft went viral on social media, and a GoFundMe created

to help fund the search for Bam Bam raised nearly \$20,000. Santiago told the Tribune he'd received calls of support from as far away as Spain and New Zealand.

Santiago said he walked up to 7 miles a day looking for his dog, who he relies on to provide some visual aid, such as helping him avoid potholes.

"No matter how many times I fall ... I always get up," Santiago said, kissing Bam Bam on the neck.

Michael Davis, who runs Best

Furry Friend Pet Rescue and Discovery based in McHenry County, said it's "miraculous" that after more than two months, Santiago and Bam Bam were back together. In many cases, lost or stolen pets never make it back to their owners, Davis said.

The first 24 hours are most critical after a dog goes missing, he said. The longer pets are separated from their owners, the more likely they are to enter "survival mode," rendering them

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Voter rolls show stark losses for Democrats

Registration shifts to GOP evident in red, blue and swing states

By **Shane Goldmacher**
and **Jonah Smith**
The New York Times

The Democratic Party is hemorrhaging voters long before they even go to the polls.

Of the 30 states that track voter registration by political party, Democrats lost ground to Republicans in every single one between the 2020 and 2024 elections — and often by a lot.

That four-year swing toward the Republicans adds up to 4.5 million voters, a deep political hole that could take years for Democrats to climb out from.

The stampede away from the Democratic Party is occurring in battleground states, the bluest states and the reddest states, too, according to a new analysis of voter registration data by The New York Times. The analysis used voter registration data compiled by L2, a nonpartisan data firm.

Few measurements reflect the luster of a political party's brand more clearly than the choice by voters to identify with it — whether they register on a clipboard in a supermarket parking lot, at the Department of Motor Vehicles or in the comfort of their own home.

And fewer and fewer Americans are choosing to be Democrats. In fact, for the first time since 2018, more new voters nationwide chose to be Republicans than Democrats last year.

All told, Democrats lost about 2.1 million registered voters between the 2020 and 2024 elections in the 30 states, along with Washington, D.C., that allow people to register with a political party. (In the remaining 20 states, voters do not register with a political party.)

Republicans gained 2.4 million. There are still more Democrats registered nationwide than Republicans, partly because of big blue states like California allow people

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INSIDE

Fight of her life

Chicago native Katie Schumacher-Cawley has a new perspective after winning a women's volleyball national title for Penn State amid her cancer battle. **Chicago Sports**

NASCAR in Joliet

A Cup Series race at the long-dormant Chicagoland Speedway in Joliet during July Fourth weekend will fill the void left by the Chicago Street Race. **Business**

RTA may transfer \$74M from Metra, Pace to CTA

Action an attempt to delay catastrophic cuts to city's transit system

By **Talia Soglin**
and **Jeremy Gorner**
Chicago Tribune

Regional transportation officials may transfer \$74 million from Metra and Pace to the CTA in an attempt to delay catastrophic cuts to Chicago's transit system.

On Thursday, Regional Transportation Authority board members will vote on the measure, which the oversight body said would help delay catastrophic cuts to the CTA early next year while all three transit agencies hope lawmakers will come to their rescue with more state funding.

The CTA, Metra and Pace

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A Pace bus and a CTA bus travel on Jackson Boulevard at Clinton Street in Chicago on Monday. The CTA, Metra and Pace are facing a budget gap in the hundreds of millions of dollars. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/TRIBUNE**

